

Biggest oil spills

Oil spills—when oil escapes into the environment—cause devastation to wildlife and are difficult and costly to clean up.

1 Gulf War oil spill, Persian Gulf, 1991
330,000–1,322,000 tons
Iraqi forces opened valves on Kuwaiti oil wells and pipes, causing a 100-mile (160-km) slick.

2 Lakeview gusher, California 1910–11
1,212,000 tons
An oil well erupted like a geyser, spilling out oil for over a year until it naturally died down.

3 Deepwater Horizon, Gulf of Mexico, 2010
740,000 tons
A deep-sea oil spill occurred when an explosion destroyed the Deepwater Horizon drilling rig.

4 Ixtoc 1 oil spill, Gulf of Mexico, USA, 1979–80
454,000–480,000 tons
The Ixtoc 1 drilling platform collapsed after an explosion. The spill continued for 9 months.

5 Atlantic Empress, Trinidad and Tobago, 1979
287,000 tons
The largest oil spill from a ship. The tanker *Atlantic Empress* hit another ship, killing 26 crew.

Lead: La Oroya, Peru
A metal smelting plant has emitted toxic lead since 1922. This has led to contaminated water supplies, dangerously polluted air, and unsafe levels of lead in the blood of local residents.

Persistent organic pollutants (POPs): Canadian Arctic
These pollutants include industrial products and pesticides. They travel on the world's oceans and air currents, accumulate in the Arctic regions, and contaminate the foods that Inuit people eat.

Pollution

Oil spills, industrial waste, and radiation leaks from nuclear power stations cause harm to people and the environment. Carbon dioxide gas (CO₂) produced by transportation and industry is adding to global warming.

THE 1991
GULF WAR OIL SLICK WAS UP TO 5 IN (13 CM) THICK

Nuclear accidents

Splitting atoms in nuclear reactors produces energy for generating electricity. Accidents at reactors may lead to radioactive material escaping, which can cause illness such as cancer for many years.



1 Chernobyl, Ukraine
April 26, 1986

A reactor explosion released radioactive material. Radiation-related illnesses may have caused thousands of deaths.